# Plato, Statesman 293c–311c: Text and Notes (Horan translation)

This companion volume continues the study of 274e–293a. It sets David Horan's translation of the Statesman (Platonic Foundation, version of 17 May 2026) beside short notes read from an orthodox Catholic point of view. Horan's text is reproduced word for word; bracketed markers such as [293c–294c] show the Stephanus range of each page of his edition, so line-exact Stephanus positions are approximate within a page. Readings credited to Mac are his own, carried forward from the prior volume and from conversation on 5 November 2026. Scripture is quoted from the Douay-Rheims (Challoner), with its numbering.

## 293c–294c — Knowledge alone makes a constitution; bees; rule for the good

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| [293c–294c] **STRANGER:** And it must also be the case with constitutions, or so it seems. The one that is pre-eminently correct and is, alone, a constitution is the one in which we would find that the rulers are truly knowledgeable and do not merely seem so, whether they rule based upon laws or in the absence of laws, with their subjects' consent or without it, and whether they themselves be poor or wealthy. None of these should be taken into consideration as a correct criterion.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Very well.<br>**STRANGER:** And whether they purify the city for its benefit by putting some people to death or casting them out, or even make it smaller by sending out colonies to somewhere like swarms of bees, or make it bigger by bringing others in from outside and granting them citizenship, as long as they have recourse to knowledge and to justice, preserve it from decline, and to the best of their ability make it better, we should declare that this constitution, in that situation and based upon such criteria, is the only correct one. Any others we mention should not be referred to as genuine, as they are not really constitutions. No, they are imitations of this one. Those that we call well-ordered have imitated it better, while the others have imitated it quite badly.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** For the most part, stranger, that seems to have been a reasonable description. However, hearing it said that we should rule without laws presented a greater difficulty.<br>**STRANGER:** You are a little ahead of me with your question, Socrates, for I was about to question you as to whether you would accept all this or had misgivings over some of what had been said. But it is now evident already that you will want us to discuss this issue of the rightness of exercising rule without laws.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** It is inevitable. | The Stranger presses the claim already prepared at 292a–293a: the one real constitution is the one where rulers truly know, whether they rule by law or without it, with consent or without it, rich or poor. Mac finds 293e fascinating and foreign by today's standards — we have largely lost this way of thinking about governance. Modern politics judges by consent, procedure and rights; Plato judges by knowledge of the good. At 276e Mac was unsatisfied with the forced-versus-voluntary split ('very libertarian' in feel); he holds that a king is not wrong to compel citizens to act rightly. Here at 293a–c Plato himself drops consent as a criterion. Align the earlier note with this: force is no longer the mark of tyranny once knowledge and justice aim at the city's good.<br>The comment on constitutions is especially poignant for Mac. For us a constitution is a written document; for the Stranger the politeia is the living order wherever real knowledge rules, and written arrangements are copies — better or worse imitations. Faith can press this further without forcing Plato: the true constitution is a Person, Christ; the Church is founded on him, not on a charter; family and parish can imitate that living order more readily than the modern state.<br>Doctor analogy continued: purge, exile, or sending out colonies 'like swarms of bees' is allowed if knowledge and justice improve the city. Mac finds the bee reference extremely interesting — bees have a rich mythological presence, and they are the animal that helps things flourish. Briefly: Virgil's Georgics IV treats the hive as a commonwealth; Ambrose's Hexameron and the Exsultet's 'mother bee' keep the same image warm in Christian imagination; and "behold there was a swarm of bees in the mouth of the lion and a honeycomb" (Judges 14:8). A swarm spreads life even when the mother-city shrinks.<br>Aquinas is close in spirit though not in dependence: law is an ordinance of reason for the common good (Summa Theologiae I–II, q. 90, a. 4); an unjust law is hardly a law |

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| **STRANGER:** Now, in a sense it is obvious that law-making belongs to kingship, yet the best course is not for the laws to prevail but for a man who is kingly and possesses wisdom to prevail. Do you know why that is?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Please tell me. Why?<br>**STRANGER:** Because a law would never be able to encompass what is best and most just for everyone at the same time in precise terms, and then institute what is best. For the dissimilarities between people and their activities, and the fact that nothing in human affairs ever really comes to rest, prevents any skill whatsoever, in any situation, from proclaiming anything simple that is applicable under all circumstances and for all time. Presumably we are agreed about that?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of course.<br>**STRANGER:** And yet we see the law striving to do just this, much like a stubborn, unlearned person, who allows no one to do anything at variance with his instruction, or to ask any question, even if something new and better occurs to someone at variance with the pronouncement he has instituted.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** This is true. Indeed, the law actually behaves toward each and every one of us in the very manner you describe. | (I–II, q. 96, a. 4). Because of the Fall he prefers a mixed regime as safeguard (I–II, q. 105, a. 1). Plato's second-best — rule by written law when the knower is absent — is about to arrive. |

## 294d–297a — Written and unwritten law; ancestral tradition; the physician's reminders

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| [294d–295d] **STRANGER:** Isn't it impossible for something that is entirely simple to be adequately applied to situations that are never simple?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Quite likely.<br>**STRANGER:** Then why ever is it necessary to make laws, when the law is never perfectly right? We must find out the reason for this.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of course.<br>**STRANGER:** Don't you also have here, as they do in other cities, courses of instruction for groups of people, relating to the running track or something else, motivated by a desire to win?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Very much so. There are a lot of them.<br>**STRANGER:** Come now, let's once again recollect the instructions of the skilled trainers when they are in such positions of authority.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** What sort of instructions?<br>**STRANGER:** They don't believe it is possible to go into detail about each | Law cannot prescribe what is best for everyone at once with precision; human affairs never sit still. So the best course is not for laws to prevail, but for the wise and kingly man. Mac finds the treatment of written and unwritten law, especially ancestral traditions, very interesting. The Stranger will soon speak of edicts on wooden or stone tablets and of unwritten ancestral practices as the city's second-best guide when the knower is away.<br>Scripture holds the same double form of tradition: "Therefore, brethren, stand fast; and hold the traditions which you have learned, whether by word, or by our epistle" (2 Thessalonians 2:14). Aquinas allows that custom can obtain the force of law (I–II, q. 97, a. 3). The physician who leaves written reminders for when he is abroad is Plato's homely image of the same point — memory for the household when the wise doctor cannot stand at every bedside.<br>Tradition as household memory fits Benedictine practice and Mac's own desire to begin such tradition in his home: not a museum of rules, but a living way handed on so that the next generation is not starting from nothing when the 'physician' is absent. |

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| individual case, and prescribe what is appropriate to each particular body. Rather, they think it necessary to issue a rough guideline that is beneficial to bodies in general, and applies in most cases.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Good.<br>**STRANGER:** Accordingly, they usually assign equal physical exertion to entire crowds, urging them all on at the same time and stopping them all at the same time, whether they are running or wrestling or undertaking any other physical exertions.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** That's what they do.<br>**STRANGER:** Then we should also presume that the lawmaker who directs this herd of ours in matters of justice, and their dealings with one another, when giving orders to entire crowds of people, will never really be capable of giving every single person precisely what is appropriate.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** That sounds reasonable, anyway.<br>**STRANGER:** Rather he will, I believe, set down a law for everyone anyway, and it will somehow, for the most part, be roughly appropriate to each individual. These he will issue in writing and in unwritten form, legislating by means of ancestral traditions.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Correct.<br>**STRANGER:** Correct indeed, Socrates. For how could anyone ever arrange to sit beside each person, constantly, throughout their life, and instruct them precisely as to what is appropriate for them? In fact, if he were capable of doing this, it is hardly likely, in my view, that anyone who had actually acquired the knowledge of kingship would ever create obstacles for himself by writing down these laws we have referred to.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes, stranger, on the basis of what we are now saying, anyway.<br>**STRANGER:** And even more so, best of men, on the basis of what we are about to say.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** On what basis is that?<br>**STRANGER:** On some such basis as this. Let's take the example of a physician, or even a gymnastic trainer, who intends to be abroad and away from those he is looking after for a considerable time, or so he believes. If he thought that the sick people, or those undergoing training, would not remember his instructions, he | |

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| would want to write down some reminders for them. Is this so?<br>**SOCRATES:** Quite so.<br>**STRANGER:** And what if he were to come back again, having been abroad for less time than expected? Would he lack the courage to propose alternatives to those written instructions if others turned out to be better for the sick people, because winds or something else from Zeus had somehow arisen unexpectedly in an unusual manner? Would he be stubborn and think that we should not step outside the ancient edicts once they have been set down –<br>**[295e–297a]** either by proposing alternatives himself or by the patient daring to act contrary to the written directions – these being the principles of medicine and health, and whatever is done differently is unhealthy and is not based upon those skills? Or would everything of this sort, at least when it occurs in the case of knowledge and true skill in all subjects, render such ordinances completely and utterly ridiculous?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Entirely so.<br>**STRANGER:** Consider the case of the person who has written laws, or framed unwritten laws, concerning just and unjust behaviour, noble and base practices, good and bad actions, intended for herds of human beings, who are herded in their particular cities based upon the laws of these writers. Is it really not permissible for different instructions, at variance with these, to be issued by the person who has the relevant skill and has written them down, or someone else like him who arrives on the scene? Or would this prohibition, in truth, appear every bit as ridiculous as the previous one?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of course it would.<br>**STRANGER:** Now, do you know the argument that most people present in such a circumstance?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Nothing relevant comes to mind at the moment.<br>**STRANGER:** Well, it sounds plausible enough. For they declare that if someone realises that there are laws at variance with those of former generations, but better, he may institute his laws once he has persuaded his own city in each case, but not otherwise.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** What about that? Is it not the right way to proceed?<br>**STRANGER:** Perhaps, but what if someone were to enforce the better course without using persuasion? Tell me what the name of that enforcement will be. | |

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| But no, not yet. Answer in relation to the previous example first.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** What are you referring to?<br>**STRANGER:** Suppose some physician, in proper possession of the relevant skill but without persuading the patient, were to compel a man, or even a woman or child, to do what is better in contravention of the written precepts. What will be the name of this kind of force? Won't it be far removed from the error we described as 'contrary to the relevant skill' and unhealthy? And the person who suffered such force may justifiably say anything at all about what happened, but may never say that he has suffered unskilled and unhealthy treatment at the hands of the physicians who forced him.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** What you say is perfectly true.<br>**STRANGER:** What, then, is the error that we refer to as being at variance with the skill of statesmanship? Isn't it baseness, evil and injustice?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Entirely so.<br>**STRANGER:** Well, what about those who have been forced, contrary to written edicts and traditions, to perform other actions, more just, better and more noble than those prescribed of old? What, for his part, could a critic of such behaviour say about such use of force, if he is to avoid becoming utterly laughable? He may say anything at all, as the occasion demands, provided he never says that those who were forced to act in that way suffered baseness or evil or injustice at the hands of those who forced them.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Very true.<br>**STRANGER:** But are the enforcements just if the person who exerts the force is wealthy, and are they unjust if he is poor? Or if the person, rich or poor, achieves something beneficial, either through persuasion or without persuasion, in conformity with the written laws or at variance with them, the truest definition of proper management of the city in this respect must surely be this: the one that a wise and good man will employ to manage the affairs of his subjects. Just as a helmsman, being constantly vigilant for the welfare of the ship and its sailors, pre- | |

## 297b–299d — Second-best city; star-gazer and sophist; Socrates' death foreshadowed

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| [297b–298b] serves his fellow sailors not by setting down written edicts, but by presenting his skill as law, so too, based upon the same approach as this, a | When the true helmsman or physician is unavailable, the city must cling to written edicts and ancestral practice; anyone who overturns them for private profit does a |

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| constitution may become a proper one on account of those who are able to rule in this way, since through their skill they provide a force that is more powerful than the laws. And those who rule intelligently, no matter what they do, avoid error as long as they are vigilant of one major principle: that they always dispense perfect justice based upon reason and skill to the people of the city, and are able, as far as possible, to preserve them and make them better people than they were.<br><br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** It is impossible to oppose what you have just said.<br><br>**STRANGER:** Nor indeed should anyone contradict those other statements of ours.<br><br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** What are you referring to?<br><br>**STRANGER:** That no large number of people of any sort would ever be able to acquire this kind of knowledge, and manage the city on the basis of reason. Rather it is in relation to something small, few, even the one, that we must seek for that single proper constitution, and we must designate the others as imitations thereof, and just as we stated a little earlier some imitate it quite well, others quite badly.<br><br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** How am I to understand what you have said? In fact, I didn't really understand your earlier statement about imitations either.<br><br>**STRANGER:** And, indeed, it would be no trivial matter if someone, having initiated this line of argument, were then to set it aside, and not even develop it to demonstrate the error that is arising about this issue at the moment.<br><br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** What sort of error?<br><br>**STRANGER:** We need to look for the kind of thing that is not particularly familiar or easy to see, and we should endeavour to lay hold of it nevertheless. Come on, then. Consider this constitution we have described, the only correct one. You know that the other constitutions must have recourse to the written laws of this one, and be preserved in this way by acting in a manner that is praised nowadays, even though it is not entirely correct to do so.<br><br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** What is it that is not entirely correct?<br><br>**STRANGER:** The notion that no one in the city should dare to do anything at variance with the laws, and whoever dares to do so should be punished by death and all sorts of extreme penalties. And yet this is entirely proper and appropriate as a second preference, whenever there is a departure from the first, the one we have described just now. So let's explain the manner in which this so-called second-best system has come into being, shall we? | worse evil still. Yet the Stranger′s satire of a city that forbids all inquiry contrary to written law lands with a jolt at 299c: the investigator is to be called neither physician nor helmsman but a ′star-gazer or a babbling sophist,′ dragged to court for ′corrupting younger people,′ and punished with the most extreme penalties, ′for none should be wiser than the laws.′<br><br>Mac reads 299c as Plato narrating Socrates′ death — the Apology charges almost word for word — while Young Socrates listens. The pattern deepens for a Christian reader: Mac notes that Christ was killed under both Jewish and Roman law (Sanhedrin and Pilate). The second-best city, clinging to its texts, rejects the one who knows; it is the pattern of the Cross. Life under such a ban on inquiry, the Stranger says, would hardly be worth living. |

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| **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes, certainly.<br>**STRANGER:** Then let's revert once more to the images, to which it has frequently been necessary to compare the kingly rulers.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** What were they?<br>**STRANGER:** The noble helmsman, and the physician who is worth as much as a thousand others. Yes, let's see if we can construct some outline based upon the people themselves.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of what sort?<br>**STRANGER:** As follows. Suppose we were all to form the notion that we are suffering outrageous treatment at the hands of these people, for they both, in like manner, preserve any of us whom they wish to preserve, and mistreat any whom they wish to mistreat. They do this by cutting us, burning us, and imposing charges to be paid to them, like a tax, out of which they spend a little or even nothing upon the patient, while they and their members make use of the rest. And what's more, they finally take money from relations, or some enemies of the patient, as payment, and then kill him. The helmsmen, for their part, perform countless other outrages of the same sort. They form conspiracies and abandon us on sea voyages, cause shipwrecks on the oceans and cast us into the sea, and perpetrate other misdeeds.<br>**[298c–299d]** Now, suppose, bearing these afflictions in mind, we were to decide upon a resolution in this regard, no longer to entrust autocratic rule to either of these two professions, neither over slaves nor over free men, a resolution to convene an assembly of ourselves, either of the entire populace or of the wealthy people alone, and to permit private citizens and the various professions to contribute an opinion on sea-faring, and on disease, and on how we should employ drugs and medical instruments in relation to the treatment of the sick, and indeed about the ships themselves, and the nautical equipment we should use on those ships in the face of dangers affecting the voyage itself, from wind and sea or also from encounters with pirates, or even perhaps in a sea battle that has to be fought in longboats against other vessels of that kind, a resolution according to which the opinions of the majority on these matters, whether the advisers be physicians, helmsmen or private citizens, once written down on wooden or stone tablets, or established as unwritten traditional practices, are to be the basis for navigating ships and for treating the sick, now and forever, for all time. | |

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| **YOUNG SOCRATES:** You have described some very odd notions.<br><br>**STRANGER:** Yes. And rulers of the people are to be appointed annually, drawn either from the wealthy classes or from the general population. And the rulers, once appointed, should rule according to the written edicts in steering the ships and healing the sick.<br><br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** This is even more difficult to accept.<br><br>**STRANGER:** Then consider what happens after this. For in each case, once the annual term of the rulers has passed, it is necessary to set up a court consisting of men either preselected from the wealthy classes or chosen by lot from the general population. The outgoing rulers must be brought before these people for scrutiny of their conduct, and anyone who wishes may accuse them of not navigating the ships, during their year in office, in accord with the written edicts or in accord with the ancient practices of our ancestors. And the same goes for those who were treating the sick. And the court must decide what penalty or fine should be imposed upon those who are voted down.<br><br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Surely anyone who desires to rule, and is willing to do so under such circumstances, would fully deserve to suffer any penalty at all or be fined any amount whatsoever.<br><br>**STRANGER:** And what's more, it will be necessary to institute a law, applicable to everything of this sort, according to which anyone who is found to be investigating helmsmanship, navigation, health, and the truth of medical science in relation to the breaths, or heat and cold, in a manner contrary to the written edicts, and is becoming in any way wise on such matters, must in the first place be referred to neither as a physician nor as a helmsman, but as a star-gazer or a babbling sophist. Secondly, anyone who is permitted to do so may drag him into some courtroom, charged with corrupting younger people and persuading them to practise helmsmanship and medicine without regard to law, and ruling over ships and sick people in an autocratic manner. And if he is presumed to have persuaded anyone, young or old, to act contrary to the laws that have been written, he must be punished with the most extreme penalties, for none should be wiser than the laws. Nor indeed need anyone be ignorant of medicine and health, or helmsmanship and navigation, for anyone who wishes is permitted to learn the written enactments and the traditional practices that are in place. Well, what if the requirements that we are describing were to apply in the case of these two branches of knowledge, Socrates, and also to generalship, to all forms of hunting whatsoever, and to painting or any part at all of the imitative arts, and to | |

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| carpentry or to manufacturing as a whole regardless of the kind, or even to agriculture and to the entire skill that is concerned with plants? Or we might also imagine it applying to some kind of horse-keeping that proceeds upon written edicts, to the entire business of herd-minding, to | |

## 299e–301a — Law as second-best; elite theory; who may set a statute aside

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| [299e–301a] prophecy and every aspect encompassed by service, to draughts-playing, or to the entire science of number, whether pure or as applied to flat surfaces, solids or moving objects. What precisely would the outcome be if all of these were conducted in such a manner as to operate on the basis of written edicts, and not on the basis of the relevant skill?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** It is obvious that all of the skills would completely cease to exist for us, and could never come back into existence again because of this law prohibiting the conduct of investigation, so that life, which is difficult even now, would at that stage not be worth living at all.<br>**STRANGER:** What about this? If we were to insist that each of the activities we mentioned be conducted according to the written edicts, and that someone be elected or chosen by lot to oversee those edicts, and yet this person, disregarding the edicts either for the sake of profit or to do some private favour, were to undertake a different course of action contrary thereto, devoid of understanding, wouldn't this evil be even greater than the previous evil?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** That's very true, anyway.<br>**STRANGER:** Indeed in my view, the laws rest upon considerable experience, and in each case certain advisers have given their counsel in a pleasing manner and have persuaded the populace to adopt them, so anyone who dares to act contrary to these would be perpetrating an even more grievous error, and would be subverting all human action to an even greater extent than any adherence to written laws.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes, that is inevitable.<br>**STRANGER:** Accordingly, the second-best course for those who enact laws and written edicts on any matter at all is to allow no single person or any group ever to do anything whatsoever that is contrary to those laws.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Rightly so.<br>**STRANGER:** Wouldn't these be imitations of the truth, in each case, as received | If someone acts contrary to the written laws for the sake of a private favour without understanding, that is worse than stiff legalism. But the man of knowledge may, like a doctor changing a prescription, act beside the written rule for the patient's good. Mac hears elite theory here: some people, on Plato's account, should stand above written law. Natural law, Mac holds, certainly binds everyone; he is less sure that every particular statute should. The only way a populace will trust a ruler above the laws, he suggests, is by divine mandate — "Let every soul be subject to higher powers: for there is no power but from God: and those that are, are ordained of God" (Romans 13:1).<br>Frame the point carefully: only Christ is truly above the law as its author. Every other ruler remains under the eternal law even when, for the common good, he sets a particular statute aside. That setting-aside is epikeia, not an optional feeling (I–II, q. 96, a. 6; II–II, q. 120). Thomas never gives a blank cheque to sheer cleverness.<br>Has St Thomas commented on this legal discourse in the Statesman? No direct commentary — the dialogue was not available to the Latin West in his day. The closest tracts are epikeia and the change of law (I–II, q. 97). Thomas agrees that law is rough and universal, but he measures every exception by the common good and the eternal law. |

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| from those who know, and written down insofar as this can be done?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** It must be so.<br>**STRANGER:** And, indeed, we said, if you remember, that the one who knows, the person who is actually a statesman, will use his skill to perform a great variety of actions relevant to his own activity, disregarding the written edicts whenever an alternative seems better to him, even if it is contrary to his own written directions to other people who are not present.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Indeed, we said so.<br>**STRANGER:** Now wouldn't anyone at all, one person or any group of people, who is faced with established laws, and undertakes some different course of action contrary to those laws because such a course is better, be doing to the best of their ability the same thing that a true statesman does?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes, certainly.<br>**STRANGER:** Now, if they were to do this sort of thing without being knowledgeable, they would endeavour to imitate the truth, but would imitate it extremely badly. Alternatively, if they possessed the relevant skill, this is no longer an imitation, but that itself, the very truest.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Entirely so, I suppose.<br>**STRANGER:** And, indeed, from our earlier discussion anyway, there is an agreement between us that no large group of people is capable of acquiring any sort of skill whatsoever.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** That agreement still stands.<br>**STRANGER:** Therefore, if there is a kingly skill, wealthy people in general, and the entire populace, could not ever acquire this knowledge of statesmanship.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** No, how could they?<br>**STRANGER:** Then it seems that if such constitutions as these intend, as best they can, to be good | |

## 301b–303c — Monarchy and tyranny; ranking the imitations; false statesmen

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| [301b–302b] imitations of that constitution ruled by a single person possessed of skill, they should never enact anything contrary to the written edicts and traditional practices, once their own laws are in place. | Once the single skilled ruler is set apart, the other constitutions are ranked as imitations: lawful monarchy best among the copies, tyranny worst; then aristocracy and oligarchy; then democracy, which is weakest for good and for harm. Mac notes that Aquinas follows Plato on monarchy versus tyranny — rule for the common good |

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| **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What you have said is excellent.<br><br>**STRANGER:** So, whenever the wealthy people imitate this, we then call a constitution of this sort an aristocracy; and when they pay no heed to the laws, we call it an oligarchy.<br><br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Quite likely.<br><br>**STRANGER:** Yes, and whenever a single person, on the basis of the laws, imitates the one who knows, we call him a king, making no distinction by name between the one who exercises sole rule on the basis of the laws by means of knowledge, and the one who does so by means of opinion.<br><br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** That's what we are likely to do.<br><br>**STRANGER:** Therefore, if a single person who really is knowledgeable happens to rule, he will unequivocally be given the same name, king, and no other. Consequently, the five names of what are now called constitutions become just one.<br><br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** So it seems, anyway.<br><br>**STRANGER:** And what about a situation in which a single person rules in accord neither with the laws nor the traditions, and pretends to be a person who knows by arguing that it is really necessary to act contrary to the written edicts and do what is best, and some passion and ignorance dominate this particular imitation? Mustn't we surely refer to any such person in that situation as a tyrant?<br><br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of course.<br><br>**STRANGER:** So we are saying that a tyrant arises in this way, a king too, as well as an oligarchy, an aristocracy, and a democracy: from the disgust of humanity with that one sole ruler, and their disbelief that anyone worthy of such rule could ever arise, someone who would be willing and able to rule with knowledge and excellence, dispensing just and sacred ordinances properly to everyone, rather than maltreating, murdering and inflicting evil upon whomsoever he wants, whenever he wants. But if a person such as we are describing were to arise, he would be loved and would dwell there as the benevolent helmsman of what is, strictly speaking, the only correct constitution.<br><br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of course.<br><br>**STRANGER:** But nowadays, when, as we say, a king does not arise in our cities in the way that a single queen bee springs up in a hive of bees – immediately distinct both in body and in soul – we need to gather together and write down | versus rule for the private good (De Regno I.1) — while adding the mixed regime as a safeguard because of the Fall.<br><br>Mac's brief observation on large modern bureaucracy: Plato and Aquinas would dislike a system that multiplies offices without knowledge or care of the common good; by their test it fares poorly, and smaller local bodies have a clearer shot at real care. Keep the point philosophical, not partisan.<br><br>The chorus of imitators returns — sophists of public affairs who are not statesmen at all. Sorting them out is the last purification before the weaver's own work can be named. |

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| our ordinances in pursuit, it seems, of the traces of the truest constitution.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Quite likely.<br>**STRANGER:** So, Socrates, need we wonder at the extent of the evil that arises and will continue to arise in such constitutions when they are based upon such a foundation as this – the performance of actions in accord with written edicts and customs not accompanied by knowledge – when it is obvious to everyone that any other skill conducted in this way would ruin its very own productions? Or should we wonder instead at something else, at how naturally strong a city is? Of course, our cities have now been suffering under such behaviour for countless ages, and yet some in particular are stable and are not overthrown. However, on occasion, many of them flounder like ships and perish, or have perished or shall yet perish, because of the depravity of the helmsmen and the sailors, who have attained a huge level of ignorance in relation to matters of the utmost importance, who are not knowledgeable about matters of statesmanship in any respect, but think that of all branches of knowledge, they have acquired this skill with the utmost clarity in every respect.<br>[302c–303c] **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Very true.<br>**STRANGER:** Now then, which of these improper constitutions is the least difficult to live under, accepting that all of them are difficult, and which is the most oppressive? Is this something we should look at even though it is a secondary consideration compared to what is now before us? And yet, on the whole it is likely that everything we do is motivated by such a consideration.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** We should do as you say, of course.<br>**STRANGER:** Then we should declare that of those three constitutions, the same one is both exceptionally difficult and easy at the same time.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** How do you mean?<br>**STRANGER:** I am just saying that monarchy, rule of the few, and rule of the many, were the three constitutions we mentioned at the beginning of the current influx of discussion.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** They were, indeed.<br>**STRANGER:** Then cutting each one of these in two we would produce six, keeping the correct one separate from these as a seventh.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** How?<br>**STRANGER:** From monarchy we get the kingly and the tyrannical subdivisions. | |

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| Then, in turn, from rule not involving many we get aristocracy, which we said has a good reputation, and also oligarchy. And furthermore, in the case of the rule of many, we proposed at the time simply to call it democracy, but now we must also propose a twofold aspect for this.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** In what way? And dividing it on what basis?<br>**STRANGER:** No differently from the others. Even if its name is already single, there is nevertheless rule according to law and rule contrary to law, both under this constitution and under the others.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** There is, indeed.<br>**STRANGER:** Now, when we were searching for the right constitution, this division was not useful, as we demonstrated in our previous discussion. However, once we have set that constitution aside, and have proposed that the others are necessary, then the criteria of ruling contrary to law or lawfully, divide each of these constitutions in two.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** So it seems, now that you have presented this argument.<br>**STRANGER:** Well then, monarchy, when yoked to good written ordinances which we call laws, is the best of the six. But when it is lawless, it is the most oppressive and difficult constitution to live under.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Quite likely.<br>**STRANGER:** Then again, just as few are intermediate between one and many, so the rule of the 'not many' should be regarded accordingly as intermediate in both respects. The rule of the many, for its part, is weak in every respect, and in comparison with the others is capable neither of great good nor of great evil, because public offices therein are distributed in minute subdivisions to many people. Therefore, when all of the constitutions are lawful, this proves to be the worst of them; and when they are all at variance with the law, it is the best; and when all of them lack restraint, the life in a democracy wins out; but when they are orderly, this is the last one you should live in. But life in the first is by far the best, with the exception of the seventh, for we must separate that one from all of the other constitutions, as we would separate a god from human beings.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** It appears that these conclusions follow, and that's how matters stand. So we should do exactly as you say.<br>**STRANGER:** In that case, we should set aside those who have a common involvement in all these constitutions, except the one based on knowledge, as not being statesmen but seditious | |

## 303d–305d — Rhetoric, generalship, judgeship: subordinate arts under the king

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| [303d–304d] influences presiding over vast images. Indeed, they are such themselves, and being the greatest imitators and beguilers, they prove to be the greatest sophists of all the sophists.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** It seems that this epithet is being turned quite rightly against the so-called statesmen.<br>**STRANGER:** So be it. This has really been like a play for us. Some troop of centaurs and satyrs was coming into view, as we said earlier, and had to be separated from the skill of statesmanship. And it has now been separated in this extremely difficult manner.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** So it appears.<br>**STRANGER:** But there is something remaining that presents an even greater difficulty than this, since it is more akin to the kingly class, and also harder to understand. Indeed, we appear to me to be in a similar predicament to those who refine gold.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** How so?<br>**STRANGER:** Presumably those craftsmen firstly separate out the earth and stones and numerous other substances, and after this, valuable admixtures akin to gold remain – copper and silver, and, on occasion, adamant – which are separable only by fire. Once these have been separated with difficulty, by repeated proving and smelting, we are allowed to behold what we call unadulterated gold alone, just by itself.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes indeed. That is how these processes are said to operate.<br>**STRANGER:** Well, according to the same account, it seems we too have separated off the others who are alien to, and lacking affinity with, the knowledge of statesmanship, leaving behind the valuable and the kindred. These presumably include generalship, legal affairs, and any rhetoric that cooperates with kingship, persuades people of what is just, and takes a share in steering the affairs of our cities. So, in what way may someone easily separate these off, and display that object of our search, naked and alone, just by itself?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** This is obviously what we should somehow try to do.<br>**STRANGER:** Then, if it's only a matter of trying, he will be made evident, and we should attempt to reveal him by recourse to music. Tell me something. | Having cleared away the imitators, the Stranger sorts three great arts that look like rule but are not: the art that persuades groups by stories rather than by teaching; the art that decides war and peace; and the art that judges according to the laws received. Each is necessary; none is statesmanship. Statesmanship directs them — recognising the right moment to persuade, to fight, or to adjudicate — as the master-weaver directs the carders.<br>This is a natural home for Mac′s priest-prophet-king lens without forcing it: prophetic speech (persuasion toward the true), kingly command (including the decision for war or peace), and the judicial care of what has been received, all ordered under one care of souls and city. The statesman does not replace these arts; he sees when each should act. |

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| **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What is it?<br>**STRANGER:** There is presumably some process of learning music, and a knowledge of manual skills in general?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** There is.<br>**STRANGER:** What about the further issue of whether it is necessary for us to learn any of these subjects or not? Shall we say that this, for its part, is also knowledge concerning the subjects themselves? What should we say?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Just that. We should say that it is.<br>**STRANGER:** Won't we agree that this form of knowledge is different from the previous ones?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes.<br>**STRANGER:** And should none of these rule any of the others, or should the others rule this one, or should this one manage and rule all of the others?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** This one should rule them.<br>**STRANGER:** So, are you of the view anyway that, according to us, the knowledge that decides whether we should learn certain subjects or not must rule over whatever knowledge is learned and taught?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Very much so.<br>**STRANGER:** And should the knowledge of whether it is necessary to persuade or not, rule over the knowledge of the ability to persuade?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of course.<br>**STRANGER:** So be it. Now, to what form of knowledge shall we assign the ability to persuade crowds<br>**[304e–305d]** and groups by telling them stories, rather than by teaching them?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** I think that this too is obvious. It should be assigned to rhetoric.<br>**STRANGER:** And the issue of whether we should perform any action whatsoever towards anyone, by means of persuasion or by some use of force, or even leave them entirely undisturbed – with which form of knowledge shall we associate this?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** With the knowledge that rules over the knowledge of persuasion and speech.<br>**STRANGER:** And that in my view would be nothing other than the power of the | |

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| statesman.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Well said.<br>**STRANGER:** Then it seems we have quickly separated this rhetoric from statesmanship, as being a different form, subservient to it.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes.<br>**STRANGER:** And what view should we hold, in turn, in relation to a power of the following kind?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** What kind?<br>**STRANGER:** The power over how we should wage war against those whom we have chosen to fight. Does this involve a skill, or is it devoid of skill?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** But how could we regard it as devoid of skill, when it is a power exercised by generalship, and military science in its entirety?<br>**STRANGER:** And the power that is able to deliberate knowledgeably on whether we should wage war or withdraw in friendship, should we understand this as different from that, or the same as that?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** To anyone following the previous discussion, it must be different.<br>**STRANGER:** In that case, shall we declare that it rules over the other one, if in fact we are going to understand it in a manner similar to the previous examples?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** I agree.<br>**STRANGER:** Now, what exactly shall we undertake to put forward in like manner as mistress of a great and fearsome skill, the art of war in its entirety, unless it really is the skill of kingship?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** None other.<br>**STRANGER:** So, we shall not propose that the knowledge belonging to the generals is statesmanship since it is subservient.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Not likely.<br>**STRANGER:** Come on, then. Let's look at the power possessed by those judges who make their judgements correctly.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Very well.<br>**STRANGER:** Now, is this power able to do anything more than take the lawfully established ordinances that it receives from the lawmaker-king, and make judgements on the basis of these by considering which arrangements are just and | |

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| which are unjust, bringing to bear its own particular excellence by which it would not be prepared to decide upon any issue between people in a manner contrary to the ordinances of the lawmaker, having been corrupted by some bribes, by fear or by lamentations, or any kind of enmity or friendship?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** No, you have pretty well explained how far the function of this particular power extends.<br>**STRANGER:** In which case we discover that the power possessed by the judges too is not kingship. Rather it is the guardian of the law and hand-maiden of kingship.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** So it seems, anyway.<br>**STRANGER:** So, we should recognise, on reviewing all of the kinds of knowledge we have mentioned, that not one of them turns out to be statesmanship. Indeed, kingship, as it really is, should not perform actions itself, but should rule over those who are able to perform actions, | |

## 305e–307d — Parts of virtue at odds; gentleness and courage

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| [305e–306d] recognising the starting point and impetus of the most important matters in the city, with a view also to what is timely and what is not, while others carry out his instructions.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Rightly so.<br>**STRANGER:** So, for these reasons, the skills we have just described rule neither over themselves nor one another, but each is concerned with some particular activity of its own, and has acquired a specific name that is appropriate to the particular nature of the activity.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes, that's what they seem to do.<br>**STRANGER:** But the knowledge that rules over all of these, superintends the laws and all the affairs of the city, and weaves everything together perfectly, has a power that is comprehended in the name belonging to the common factor, and, it seems, may quite properly be referred to as statesmanship.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Entirely so.<br>**STRANGER:** Well, wouldn't we also like to take this further, based upon the example of weaving, now that all the classes relevant to the city have become evident to us? | The dialogue turns to the weave itself. Courage and sound-mindedness (gentleness, orderliness) are both parts of virtue, yet in practice they pull apart and even oppose one another. Praise of quiet order can slide into praise of soft inactivity; praise of vigour can slide into praise of reckless speed. Mac finds the conversation on gentleness and firmness at 307a especially interesting, and hears Good Shepherd imagery in it: "He shall feed his flock like a shepherd: he shall gather together the lambs with his arm, and shall take them up in his bosom, and he himself shall carry them that are with young" (Isaias 40:11).<br>Fr. Moreau's Christian education speaks the same blend. Circular Letter 79 (1857): the mission should be fulfilled with that 'happy blending of gentleness and firmness, prudence and vigilance, which is the secret of all successful education.' Mac also hears a distant parallel to Machiavelli's fox and lion (Prince XVIII) — two natures needed together — but the end is wholly different: power in one case, the good of the city and of souls in the other. |

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| **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes, very much so.<br>**STRANGER:** Then it seems we should state what kind of process the kingly intertwining is, the manner in which it does the intertwining, and the sort of fabric it presents us with.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Obviously.<br>**STRANGER:** In that case, it has apparently become necessary to give an exposition of a difficult matter.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** There's no other option anyway. It should be delivered.<br>**STRANGER:** Indeed, the assertion that a part of excellence is, in a sense, contrary in form to excellence in general is very easily assailed by those who are skilled in verbal disputation by an appeal to the opinions of the majority.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** I do not understand.<br>**STRANGER:** Then I'll restate it as follows, for I presume you regard courage, for us, to be one part of excellence.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Entirely so.<br>**STRANGER:** Yes. And self-control is different from courage, but this too is one part of that which courage is part of.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes.<br>**STRANGER:** Then we must dare to pronounce a wondrous doctrine in relation to these.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of what sort?<br>**STRANGER:** That these two, in a certain sense, are very much enemies of one another, and they hold opposing positions in many actual situations.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** How do you mean?<br>**STRANGER:** The doctrine is not at all familiar, since in fact all the parts of excellence are usually said to be friendly towards one another in some sense.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes.<br>**STRANGER:** Should we then apply our minds diligently and consider whether this is simply the way it is, or is it more the case that some of these are in opposition to their own kindred in some respect?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes, you should explain how we should consider this issue.<br>**STRANGER:** It is necessary to investigate all of those circumstances in which | |

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| we refer to things as good, but nevertheless assign them to two forms opposite to one another.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Explain this more clearly.<br>**STRANGER:** Take acuity and speed, whether of body or soul, or in the delivery of a speech. Have you yourself ever praised any of these qualities themselves, either directly or in whatever<br>**[306e–307d]** images of them are provided by musical or pictorial imitation? Or have you ever been present to hear someone else praising them?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of course.<br>**STRANGER:** And can you recall the manner in which they did so in each of these cases?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Not at all.<br>**STRANGER:** Now, I wonder if I'll be capable of using words to present to you exactly what is in my mind.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** But why not?<br>**STRANGER:** You seem to think that this sort of issue is easy. But we really should consider it in those cases in which the skills are opposed. For of course, on many occasions, when we are pleased by the speed, intensity or acuity of numerous actions, be they mental or physical or even vocal, we speak in praise of this by using a single designation, the word 'courage'.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** How so?<br>**STRANGER:** I am presuming in the first place that we say 'acute and courageous', and we also say 'quick and courageous', and the same goes for 'intense'. And in applying the name that I am uttering in common to all of these natures, we are praising them.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes.<br>**STRANGER:** Ye s. But haven't we, on many occasions, also praised the form of gentleness that occurs in many activities?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes, very much so.<br>**STRANGER:** Of course, what we say about this is the opposite of what we say about those other qualities.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** In what way?<br>**STRANGER:** In the sense that in these cases we say 'calm' and 'sound-minded' | |

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| when admiring activities in the mental realm; then again, ‘slow’ and ‘gentle’ when it relates to physical actions; and to ‘smooth’ and ‘deep’ in relation to the working of the voice and to all rhythmical motion and any music that makes opportune use of slowness. To all these activities we do not apply the term ‘courage’, but ‘orderliness’.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Very true.<br>**STRANGER:** And yet, on the other hand, whenever in our view they both occur inopportunely, we turn around and censure each of them, assigning them to their opposites by the names we use.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** In what way?<br>**STRANGER:** By saying that those that occur with more acuity than is opportune, or appear too rapid or harsh are violent and manic, while those that are heavier, slower and more gentle are cowardly or sluggish. And we shall find generally, for the most part, that these qualities, along with the sound-minded nature and the courage associated with the opposite qualities, acting as if enmity was their fate, do not mix with one another in activities concerned with such issues. And if we pursue the enquiry further, we shall observe that those who hold them within their souls are at variance with one another too.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Where do you propose that we observe this?<br>**STRANGER:** In all the cases we mentioned just now, and probably in many others besides. For on the basis of their own kinship with one set of qualities or the other, I think that they praise one as their own kindred, and censure those belonging to their adversaries as alien, and they adopt highly inimical stances towards one another on numerous issues.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Very likely.<br>**STRANGER:** Now, at this stage, the adversity between these forms is mere childishness. However, | |

## 307e–308e — Test them first in play; educators as carders of the web

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| [307e–308e] when it relates to matters of the utmost importance, it turns out to be the most virulent disease of all those that afflict our cities.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** What sort of important matters are you referring to?<br>**STRANGER:** This is likely to involve the entire planning for living. For of | Mac points to 308a: true statesmanship will never willingly assemble a city from good and bad materials mixed. It tests people first in play, then entrusts them to educators, while itself directing those educators as a weaver directs carders — telling each what the web requires. |

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| course, those who are especially orderly are always ready to live the quiet life alone, just by themselves, occupying themselves with their own activities. What's more, they interact in this manner with everyone in their home city, and likewise towards foreign cities, being ready to maintain some manner of peace by any means. And because this love of theirs is most inopportune, whenever they behave as they wish to behave, they overlook the fact that they themselves, by maintaining an unmilitary stance, also influence the young towards a similar disposition. Consequently, they are continually beset by adversaries, and it is not long before they themselves, their children and their entire city become slaves rather than a free people, often without them being aware of it.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** What you are describing is harsh, and a terrible predicament indeed.<br>**STRANGER:** But what about those who are more inclined towards courage? Aren't they constantly drawing their own cities into some war or other because of their excessively strong desire for such a life? And once they have made many powerful enemies, they either utterly destroy their own native land or reduce its people to slaves and underlings of their enemies.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes, that happens too.<br>**STRANGER:** So how could we deny that in such situations these types always maintain a great deal, indeed a huge amount, of enmity and rivalry towards one another?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** There is no way at all we can deny it.<br>**STRANGER:** In that case, haven't we found what we were looking for initially – that parts of excellence, of no minor significance, are naturally at variance with one another? And, what's more, they make those who possess them behave exactly as they do?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** So it seems.<br>**STRANGER:** Then there is another issue we should take up.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of what kind?<br>**STRANGER:** Does any knowledge concerned with putting things together willingly assemble even the most trivial of its own productions from inferior and serviceable materials combined? Or is it that any knowledge in any situation discards the inferior as best it can, retains what is suitable and serviceable, and, from these, be they similar or dissimilar, constructs a single power and form by bringing them all together into a unity? | What does 'test them first in play' mean? Watch them in games and childhood pastimes, where the soul shows its bent without the masks of adult performance; only then educate for the weave. Those who cannot share in courage and sound-mindedness, but are driven into godlessness, violence and injustice, the king finally removes by exile, death, or loss of status; the extremely base he subjects to slavery. Harsh by modern ears — read it beside the earlier doctor analogy and the demand that knowledge aim at the city's good, not at private passion. |

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| **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of course.<br>**STRANGER:** Then neither will this statesmanship of ours, being natural and true, ever willingly assemble any city from serviceable people and bad people. Rather, it is quite obvious that it will test them first in play, and after that test it will go on to entrust them to those who are capable of educating them, and serving statesmanship in this respect, while for its own part it provides direction and superintendence, just as weaving pays close attention, and directs and superintends the carders – and those who furnish it with whatever it needs for its web – by indicating to each of them the sort of tasks it thinks it is appropriate for them to complete in relation to its own intertwining.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Entirely so.<br>**STRANGER:** It appears to me that kingship does exactly the same thing. Retaining for itself the power of superintendence, it will not permit the lawful educators and nurturers to engage in any practice that does not bring about some characteristic that is appropriate to the overall blend, and it exhorts them to educate on this basis alone. But those who are unable to share in courage and sound-mindedness, and any other characteristics that are conducive | |

## 309a–310a — Divine bond of steadfast true opinion; baptismal reading

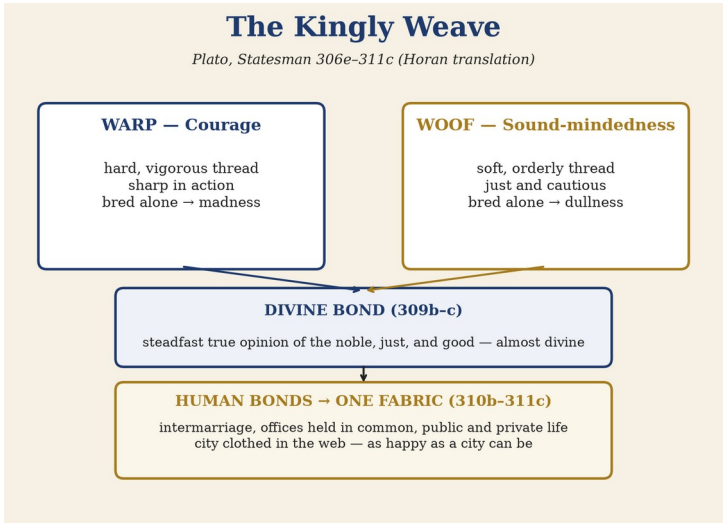
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| [309a–310a] to excellence, but are thrust away by the force of an evil nature into godlessness, violence and injustice, these it casts out through execution, exile, or punishing them with significant loss of status.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Something of this sort is said to happen anyway.<br>**STRANGER:** While those who wallow in ignorance and extreme baseness it subjects to the yoke of slavery.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Quite right.<br>**STRANGER:** As for the others then, there are some whose natures are amenable to attaining nobility, if they obtain education and will accept being mixed with one another on the basis of a skill. Of these, it regards the ones who are more inclined towards courage as akin to warp threads due to their hard character, while those inclined to orderliness make use of a rich, soft, and, according to this image, a woof-like thread. These two natures, with their opposite inclinations, it attempts to bind and weave together in some such manner, as follows. | Warp and woof are named: the hard, courageous natures as warp; the soft, orderly natures as woof. First the statesman joins the ever-begotten part of their soul by a divine bond, then the mortal part by human bonds. At 309b–c: whenever opinion that is really true concerning the noble, just and good — and their opposites — arises in souls with steadfastness, that opinion is divine, and it arises in a class that is almost divine.<br>Mac calls 309b a great psychological analysis, and notes a careful parallel (not an identity) with the Prussian officer quadrants he has discussed with Augustine (Hammerstein-Equord: clever/stupid × lazy/diligent). Plato's axes are courage and gentleness transformed by steadfast true opinion; the Prussian grid is an operational personnel tool. Different purpose; similar instinct to sort dispositions before trusting them with the work.<br>Mac hears Plato wrapping the discourse with something that sounds like an argument toward baptism: a divine bond of steadfast true opinion about the noble, just and good, poured into an almost-divine class. He points especially at 309c. The image of blood and water from the side of Christ — "But one of the soldiers with a spear |

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| **YOUNG SOCRATES:** How is it done?<br>**STRANGER:** First, based upon kinship, it joins together the ever-begotten part of their soul by a divine bond, and then after the divine, it joins the mortal part of them with human bonds.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Again, what do you mean by this?<br>**STRANGER:** Whenever opinion that is really true – concerning whatever is noble, just and good, and their opposites – arises in souls, accompanied by steadfastness, I say this is divine, and it arises in a class that is almost divine.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** It is quite appropriate to say so.<br>**STRANGER:** Now, are we aware that it belongs to the statesman and the good lawgiver alone, by means of the kingly Muse, to be able to engender this particular opinion in those who have acquired education in the right way, the people we described just now?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** That sounds reasonable.<br>**STRANGER:** Anyway, Socrates, we would never use the names we are now investigating to refer to anyone who was unable to perform this function.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** No.<br>**STRANGER:** Well now, won't a courageous soul be made gentle once it has grasped this sort of truth, and, consequently, have more communion with whatever is just, if it so wishes? But if it has no share in this, won't it be more inclined towards a wild nature?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** That is inevitable.<br>**STRANGER:** But what about the orderly nature? If it shares in these opinions, doesn't it become genuinely self-restrained and wise, by the standard of civic life anyway? But if it does not share in the opinions we are describing, doesn't it quite rightly acquire a reprehensible reputation for folly?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Entirely so.<br>**STRANGER:** In that case, shouldn't we declare that this intertwining and binding will never become stable in bad people bound to their own kind, nor in good people bound to bad people, nor would any knowledge ever seriously use it in such cases?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of course.<br>**STRANGER:** And yet, in those characters born with innate nobility from the very outset, whose upbringing accords with their nature, in these alone it is | opened his side, and immediately there came out blood and water″ (John 19:34) — gives Baptism and Eucharist as the divine bond poured out. Plato does not know that name; the Christian reader may recognise the shape. |

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| implanted by the laws, and this indeed is a remedy skilfully applied to them. And just as we said, this bonding together is more divine since it unites parts of excellence that are dissimilar by nature and tend in opposite directions.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Very true. | |

## 310b–311c — Human bonds; will to power; the finished fabric of the city

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| [310b–311c] **STRANGER:** The remaining bonds are, of course, human, and once this divine bond is in place, it is not particularly difficult either to devise the others, or to implement them once devised.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** How would you do so? And what are they?<br>**STRANGER:** I mean bonds forged between communities through intermarriage and the community of their children, and those associated with private property exchange and marriage. Indeed, with respect to the procreation of children, most people make such arrangements in an incorrect manner.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** How is that?<br>**STRANGER:** By the pursuit of wealth and power through such arrangements. But why would anyone seriously regard the censure of this as a worthy discussion topic?<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** There is no reason.<br>**STRANGER:** No. It would be more correct to discuss those who pay attention to the families when making such arrangements, in case they do so in an inappropriate manner.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes, that's reasonable anyway.<br>**STRANGER:** In fact, they do not act based upon a single correct principle, for they pursue the easiest option available, embrace those who are much like themselves, and have no affection for those who are dissimilar. They assign the utmost significance to their feeling of displeasure.<br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** In what way?<br>**STRANGER:** The orderly people seek out their own characteristic, and as best they can they marry those types and bestow their own offspring upon such people again when giving them in marriage. And the courageous type do the very same, by pursuing their own nature, when both of these types should be really doing the exact opposite. | Once the divine bond is in place, human bonds — intermarriage, shared children, exchange — are easier to forge. Most people arrange these badly, chasing wealth and power, or simply marrying their own likeness. Mac hears at 310b a discussion of the will to power: God gives certain people incredible innate capacities, yet courage bred alone for many generations ends in madness, and unchecked moderation ends dull and maimed. Gift without measure hardens. 'For all different types of things,' as Mac puts it — every gift (intellect, beauty, wealth, authority, gentleness) can ripen into service or harden into self-will.<br>The sole function of the kingly weaving is never to let the sound-minded stand apart from the courageous, but to weave them through unanimity into one fabric, entrusting public offices to both together — or to someone who holds both. Cautious justice without vigour is incomplete; vigour without caution is incomplete. Public and private affairs need both.<br>Closing image: the disposition of the courageous and the sound-minded, woven in an even texture, is the finished fabric of statesmanship. Kingship clothes the whole city, slave and free, in that web, and superintends so that the city may be as happy as a city can be. Socrates (the elder) receives the account: a most beautiful account of the kingly man, the statesman. A Catholic reader may quietly see the Church as a woven body — many members, one care — and Mac's priest-prophet-king frame as three threads that belong in one Person and, by gift, in the baptized. Plato's last word is the fabric; ours may add the Weaver who is also the Lamb. |

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| **YOUNG SOCRATES:** In what way, and why?<br><br>**STRANGER:** Because it is natural that courage, propagated for many generations without being mixed with a sound-minded nature, flourishes powerfully at first, but in the end bursts forth in utter madness.<br><br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** That is likely.<br><br>**STRANGER:** In contrast, the soul that is too full of moderation, bred over many generations without admixture of daring courage, grows unseasonably dull and ends up totally maimed.<br><br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes. That is the likely outcome.<br><br>**STRANGER:** Now, I said that these bonds were not difficult to forge once a single opinion about what is noble and good, held by both classes, was in place. For this is the sole function of the kingly weaving process as a whole: never to allow the sound-minded characters to stand apart from the courageous, but to weave them together through unanimity, by granting privileges or withdrawing them, through reputation and the mutual exchange of sureties. He should then assemble them into what we call a well-woven fabric, and always entrust the public offices in our cities, in common, to these two.<br><br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** In what way?<br><br>**STRANGER:** When a single official happens to be required, it chooses someone possessing both to take charge, and when a greater number is needed, it combines together a portion of each of the two types. For when the sound-minded characters rule, they are extremely cautious, just and safe, and yet they lack a certain sharp, practical vigour.<br><br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes. That's what seems to happen anyway.<br><br>**STRANGER:** But the courageous types, by contrast, although inferior to the other types when it comes to justice and caution, still possess exceptional vigour in practical situations. However, it is impossible for all the affairs of our cities, public as well as private, to proceed well without both these qualities being available to them.<br><br>**YOUNG SOCRATES:** No, how could they?<br><br>**STRANGER:** And we may say that this disposition of the courageous and of the sound-minded people, once woven together in an even texture, constitutes the finished fabric of the activity of statesmanship whereby the skill of kingship, having brought these together through likemindedness and friendship into a common life, and having completed the most magnificent and excellent of all |  |

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| fabrics, embraces all the other people in our cities, slaves and free, by clothing them in this woven web, and rules and superintends thereafter, omitting nothing that renders the city as happy as it belongs to any city to be.<br>**SOCRATES:** Now, stranger, you have also completed for us a most beautiful account of the kingly man, the statesman. | |